ART ▼

HUMANS, **DREAMED AND TAKEN APART**

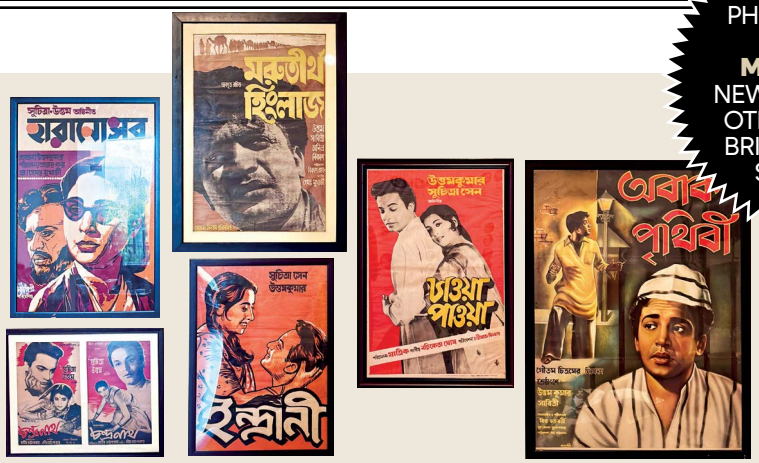
A NEW EXHIBITION IN KOLKATA'S **AKAR PRAKAR** TURNS THE HUMAN BODY INTO A SITE FOR QUESTIONS ABOUT IDENTITY



Akar Prakar gallery's latest exhibition, *Friends*, combining select paintings and sculptures by Tapan Bhattacharya and the late Vivan Sundaram, provides contrasting perspectives on the human form. While Sundaram's mixed-media sculptures taking apart human anatomy reveal the tactile building blocks behind human identity and the concept of the self, Bhattacharya's paintings distort the human form and add a dreamlike component wherein humans are considered at their most elemental.

In Bhattacharya's words, his art "speaks of the irreducibility of imagined forms". The humans in his paintings "recall creature forms but reject likeness". Indeed, some of his creations remain

ANECDOTES, PHOTOGRAPHS, **POSTERS, MAGAZINES,** NEWSPAPERS AND OTHER OBJECTS BRING ALIVE THE SUPERSTAR



A HERO'S MANY GUISES A collection of posters of Bengali films starring Uttam Kumar

EXHIBITION ▼

Making of a Mahanayak

A centenary exhibition in Kolkata reveals the man behind the myth that was **Uttam Kumar**

"There are two people Bengal will forgive everything for, no matter the crime," asserted Sanjoy Mukhopadhyay, a film studies scholar, at a talk for the exhibition *GURU—Uttam Kumar at 100: The Making of Bengal's Eternal Star*. "One of them is a fictional character, Devdas; the other is actor Uttam Kumar." Interestingly, the titular role of Devdas in the 1979 film was played by Kumar's 'rival', actor Soumitra Chattopadhyay. Chattopadhyay's daughter, thespian Poulomi Bose, also alludes to the rivalry. "People loved pitting my father Soumitra against Uttam Kumar. But at home, Uttam *jethu* (uncle) was a revered figure," she says.

Stories like this, through photographs, posters, a gramophone that plays his hit film songs, and magazines and newspapers bring alive the man that Kumar was. Curated by writer Trinankur Banerjee in collaboration with West Bengal Motion Picture Artists' Forum and Kolkata Kothakatha, the exhibition pays tribute to the superstar without glossing over his failings. "Behind the image of the Mahanayak was a long process of becoming, shaped by perseverance, reinvention and a remarkable network of creative collaborations. This exhibition looks at that process," explains the curator. ■

—Malini Banerjee

The exhibition is on display at the Kolkata Centre for Creativity till Oct. 11